things had not been going well for him, so I encouraged him to set some targets and concentrate on meeting them. We really needed a fully focused Yuvraj and I am delighted to say that's what we got from him all the way through the tournament.

It is a priceless moment in a cricketer's career when he lines up for the national anthem at the start of a multi-nation competition. Right through my career, listening to the anthem while standing alongside my team-mates has given me goosebumps. As they played the 'Jana Gana Mana' at Mirpur, none of us could hold back our emotions. We knew that for the millions of Indians supporting us, what we were playing was not just a game but a passion.

We won the toss and Virender Sehwag and I stepped out to start our campaign. Viru began in style, hitting the very first ball for a four, and we were off. The early nerves disappeared in no time and we started to enjoy ourselves. We set up a good foundation, scoring at a fair clip, before I was run out for 28 and then Gautam Gambhir for 39. Viru was sublime in his innings of 175 and Virat Kohli contributed a superbly orchestrated century to help take us to 370–4. In the end we won the match comfortably by 87 runs. The 2007 defeat had been avenged and we were off to the start we had hoped for.

An epic encounter

Our next match was against England in Bangalore on 27 February and, as it was our first match at home, the excitement was off the scale.

Something a little odd happened just hours before the England match. In the tournament I was using a favourite bat of mine, the one I had used the previous season, when I was the ICC Cricketer of the Year. Though it was showing its age, I had not discarded it. Rather, I had repaired it time and again and had even sent it to the bat manufacturers for restoration. There was a kind of emotional bond with this bat and every time I couriered it to the manufacturers I felt nervous and prayed that it would not get lost in transit. In the dressing room, with just a few hours left until the match, for some reason I started to knock in a brand-new bat and work on it in my usual way to get the weight exactly right. I even remember telling myself that I was being foolish and wasting my time, because there was no way I would be using a new bat and I would be better off concentrating on the game.